

By late pregnancy, the length of your baby can no longer fit on the screen, so your doctor will calculate their size by combining several measurements in a mathematical formula, as is done at the [20-week scan](#). Measurements include the width of the head (biparietal diameter), circumference of the head, and the abdominal circumference, which are plotted on a graph over a period of time (see [Doppler scans](#)). The length of the upper leg bone (femur length) may also be measured. If your baby is smaller than the 10th percentile or has a small abdomen, you may have more tests to assess their well-being (see below). A measurement above the 90th percentile can be a sign of [gestational diabetes](#) and will need investigating. Also, if your baby is thought to weigh over 11 lb (5 kg), your doctor will discuss with you the option of a Cesarean section.

If there are concerns over your baby's growth, you may be referred for fetal heart-rate monitoring and/or biophysical profile testing, which observe how your baby responds to stimuli and whether there are signs of distress. If you have a known condition that can affect your [baby's growth](#), your doctor may arrange for you to have one or both tests once or twice a week after about 32 weeks. Some doctors perform [Doppler scans](#) to assess placental blood flow when the baby is small for gestational age.

A nonstress test This test assesses your baby's well-being. An external transducer is placed on your abdomen to listen for accelerations in your baby's heart rate that last about 15 seconds. You may or may not notice any fetal movement during these accelerations. The test result is said to be "reassuring" if the heart accelerates twice over 20–30 minutes and no large decelerations occur. About 10–20 percent of babies have a test with less than two accelerations. This doesn't necessarily mean a problem exists; your baby may just have been asleep, and the test may be repeated.

A biophysical profile (BPP) If, after the nonstress test, your doctor still has concerns, a BPP may be done. A BPP combines the results of a CTG reading to evaluate four factors: the volume of amniotic fluid, fetal movement, fetal muscle tone and posture, and fetal breathing. Two points are given for each part of the test, so a "reassuring" BPP result would be eight points.

DOPPLER SCANS

A Doppler scan analyzes blood flow through the placenta. If the placenta is functioning well, the blood flows easily. If there is a problem, the placenta is resistant to the blood flow and the baby's heart has to work harder to pump blood. In extreme cases, there are periods between your baby's heartbeats of no blood flow or reversed blood flow and an early delivery may be suggested.